WEBSITE CONTENT

WHAT MUST I DO TO BE SAVED?

The following notes were made by Apostle T. G. Mapiye.

This is a very important question if not the most important question ever asked. This question has been asked in different ways in the Bible but the answer remains the same. The answer to the question, “What must I do to be saved?” is very important.

A Jewish lawyer approached the Lord Jesus Christ one day and asked, "What shall I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus answered by asking a question, "What is written in the Law? How does it read to you?" (Luke 10:26). The intelligent religious student replied by quoting two verses from the Old Testament. Luke quotes his response in Luke 10:27. "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your strength, and with all your mind; and your neighbor as yourself." Then Jesus quoted Leviticus 18:5, "Do this, and you will live." The problem of mankind is that mankind cannot obey God 100% using their own human effort. James 2:10 says, "For whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles in one point, he has become guilty of all." All of us, including the best of us have sinned against God. "If we say that we have not sinned, we make Him a liar, and His word is not in us" (1 John 1:10) It may be truly said, "There is none righteous, not even one" (Romans 3:10). “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23). When man stands before God he is neither righteous, nor able to perform righteous deeds that will satisfy God. "All our righteousness are like filthy rags" before the LORD God (Isaiah 64:6). Romans 3:20 cannot be any clearer. "By the works of the Law no flesh will be justified in His [God's] sight; for through the law comes the knowledge of sin." Sinful man cannot live up to the holy demands of God's law. No one is righteous in the eyes of God. The work of salvation was completely finished once and for all by Jesus on the cross. God receives all sinners who repent and put their trust in Christ to save them. We are justified through faith, and not through any works or obedience on our part.

On the Day of Pentecost, after Christ went to Heaven, Peter preached his first sermon. He preached about Jesus Christ, the one whom the Jews had crucified in ignorance and proved to them that the same Jesus whom they had nailed to the cross was both Messiah and Lord. He told the people that Christ had died for their sins and had been resurrected from the dead and ascended to heaven. After Peter finished preaching, the people said, "Men and brethren, what shall we do?" (Acts 2:37). Peter told them, "Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins: and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost" (Acts 2:38). Again in the Bible, a jailer asked his prisoners, Paul and Silas: “’Sirs, what must I do to be saved?’ So they said, ‘Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and you will be saved….’” (Acts 16:30-31). To “believe in the Lord Jesus Christ” means to place your trust, your faith, and your hope in the person and work of Jesus Christ, whose sinless life and sacrificial death are alone able to reconcile the broken relationship you have created with God as a result of your sins against Him. It also means believing that He alone conquered death by resurrecting from the dead and is still alive today forever more and will come back to take the righteous to be with Him forever eternally.

The jailor was brought under deep conviction, leading him to seek the Lord and to ask the question, “What must I do to be saved?” Nobody ever turns to the Lord for salvation until he first feels his need to be saved. A man will not escape from danger unless he sees it. The preaching of the gospel brings this awareness to man. The jailer received a concise answer, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you shall be saved you and your household" (Acts 16:31). While it remains for the sinner to accept what God has already done, a sinner needs be reminded that he cannot save himself from sin, but only Jesus can save Him. All attempts to live up to the law only proves our repeated failures. No matter how good of a person you think you are right now or how good of a person you plan to be in the future, you can never be good enough to go to heaven because God’s standard is perfect righteousness and you have already failed that standard (and will again). Human goodness can never be good enough. Both those who think they are good people and the really bad people are all the same against heaven’s standards.

The good news is that what we could not do for ourselves was already done for us by God through Jesus Christ. "[God] made Him [Jesus Christ] who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him" (2 Corinthians 5:21). The Son of God, Jesus Christ, obtained the righteousness for us through His death for our sins. It is the only kind of righteousness that God will accept. “For while we were still helpless, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly. For one will hardly die for a righteous man; though perhaps for the good man someone would dare even to die. But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us. Much more then, having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from the wrath of God through Him. (Romans 5:8-9).

After understanding these realities, you must agree with God that you have sinned against Him and that you deserve judgment for it. You must repent of your sin, which means that you turn in a new direction away from your sin and commit to following God, relying on Him for the strength to do so. The days of your ignorance, God has overlooked or put a waiver on them because you were ignorant of the truth. “God is now declaring to men that all people everywhere should repent, because He has fixed a day in which He will judge the world in righteousness through a Man [Jesus Christ] whom He has appointed, having furnished proof to all men by raising Him from the dead” (Acts 17:30-31).

“For God so loved the world, that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish, but have eternal life. For God did not send the Son into the world to judge the world, but that the world might be saved through Him.” (John 3:16-17) "You were not redeemed with perishable things like silver or gold from your futile way of life inherited from your forefathers, but with precious blood, as of a lamb unblemished and spotless, the blood of Christ" (1 Peter 1:18-19).

"The wages of sin is death” (Romans 6:23). Jesus, God's Son, died upon the cross in the sinner's place. God has accepted the sacrifice of His Son—our Lord Jesus Christ—on our behalf. It is God's gift to the sinner. It is without payment of any kind. It is by grace alone, through faith alone in Christ alone. All that is required of you this day to receive the free gift of eternal life is believe on Christ as your personal Saviour. Only by believing can a person appropriate the gift of God. Ask Him to save you right now. Believe on Him and you shall be saved.

“The Word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart — that is, the word of faith which we are preaching, that if you confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved; for with the heart a person believes, resulting in righteousness, and with the mouth he confesses, resulting in salvation. For the Scripture says, “whoever believes on Him will not be disappointed.” For there is no distinction between Jew and Greek [Gentile]; for the same Lord is Lord of all, abounding in riches for all who call on Him; for “whoever will call on the name of the Lord will be saved” (Romans 10:8-13).

“Not everyone who says to Me, ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of heaven, but he who does the will of My Father who is in heaven will enter. Many will say to Me on that day, ‘Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name, and in Your name cast out demons, and in Your name perform many miracles?’ And then I will declare to them, ‘I never knew you; depart from me, you who practice lawlessness’” (Matthew 7:21-23).

Example of a prayer to receive the Lord Jesus Christ:

“Father, I know that I have broken your laws and my sins have separated me from you. I am truly sorry, and now I want to turn away from my past sinful life toward you. Please forgive me, and help me avoid sinning again. I believe that your son, Jesus Christ died for my sins, was resurrected from the dead, is alive, and hears my prayer. I invite Jesus to become the Lord of my life, to rule and reign in my heart from this day forward. Please send your Holy Spirit to help me obey You, and to do Your will for the rest of my life. In Jesus' name I pray, Amen.”

A true Christian confesses Christ by joining with others in fellowship, in worship and in service. If you have trusted the Lord Jesus Christ through our website, please get in touch with us to receive further instructions. It is also important that you join a Church that upholds similar beliefs and you begin your spiritual journey by reading your Bible every day to find out what God requires of you and you pray every day to maintain your relationship with God.

“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creature; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come. Now all these things are from God, who reconciled us to Himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation, namely, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and He has committed to us the word of reconciliation. Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were making an appeal through us; we beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God. He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him” (2 Corinthians 5:17-21).

“For by grace you have been saved through faith; and that not of yourselves, it is the gift of God; not as a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand so that we would walk in them” (Ephesians 2:1-10)

GUIDELINES FOR READING THE BIBLE

The following notes were made by Apostle T. G. Mapiye.

How to read the Bible

Be diligent to present yourself approved to God as a workman who does not need to be ashamed, handling accurately the word of truth. 2 Timothy 2:15.

After Jesus rose from the dead, one of the things He did was to explain the Scriptures to his disciples. In Luke chapter twenty four, verse twenty seven, we read, And beginning with Moses and with all the prophets, He explained to them the things concerning Himself in all the Scriptures. Even today, Jesus through the Holy Spirit is explaining the things concerning Himself through the Scriptures. Make a commitment to hear the Lord's voice through the pages of your Bible.

It is not healthy for Christians to live without spending time in prayers and in reading their Bibles.

Many people browse through pages of the Bible without careful study and in most cases miss the main message that the Scriptures convey. It is very possible to read the Bible and understand it.

The Bible is inspired, and we must seek out its complete message in order to provide a Scriptural balance to our interpretation. When we read the Bible, our aim should be to extract the meaning of the text and not to read into the text our own beliefs or ideas. Avoid self-centered reading of the Bible supposing that any or all parts apply to you or your group in a way that they do not apply to everyone else. It is an error to read a single verse in isolation, forgetting that it has an immediate context and the original context and cultural setting of the Bible. It is very common for people to read into a biblical narrative suggestions or ideas that come from contemporary culture that are simultaneously foreign to the narrator's purpose and contradictory to his point of view. They ignore the Holy Spirit and appropriate the text for purposes that are quite foreign to the biblical narrative. Another serious problem is changing the original definitions of certain words in the Bible to suit a church doctrine. When the plain meaning of the text leaves people cold, producing no immediate spiritual delight or saying something other than what they wish it said, they are often tempted to redefine it to mean something else. Sometimes people do this out of ignorance and sometimes deliberately to benefit something through such misinterpretations. Having said this, the Holy Spirit is our teacher and guide into all truth and must always be obeyed.

Scripture often interprets itself. The Bible is its own best interpreter. A good example is the parable of the sower in Luke chapter 8. After Jesus shares the parable, his disciples asked him what this parable meant? Jesus answered them and gave them the meaning of the parable. If someone comes up with a

different meaning from what the Lord Jesus clearly taught, they we know that the person has misinterpreted the Bible passage.

The words although written in ink and in human languages came from God. The inspiration came from God even though human authors were employed to put the words in written form. It is important to ask God for help through the Holy Spirit, every time we want to read the Bible. The way a person interprets the Bible will affect their walk with Christ and the beliefs they hold. You are responsible for your own interpretation of the Bible. One common mistake that many people make when reading the Bible is to let the issues of our day interpret the Bible. God, through the Holy Spirit inspired the human writers of Scripture, who used their own languages in their historical setting to convey their meaning. The author's meaning should control our interpretation of any passage of Scripture and we should never impose our own meanings to the Scriptures. When we do this we are Biblical and sound.

Before we interpret the Bible we must establish the original author's intention both in time and logic in any book we choose to read.

Words have meaning only in context; clauses have meaning only in context; sentences have meaning only in context. Do not rush to apply verses of Scripture without understanding the whole passage or paragraph. Interpretation and understanding must happen before application.

In applying the Bible, it is important to remember that (except in prophecy) one and only one meaning is valid for a particular Bible text. Many possible applications may be derived from this one meaning.

The Bible must be seen as God's written word before we read it. To read the Bible thoughtlessly or carelessly or academically or professionally is not to read the Bible as God's written Word. Our attitude and approach towards the Bible can affect our understanding.

How to make Bible Study Notes:

Before you read any book of the Bible, you need to understand the following background:

1, the author. Who wrote the book?

2, the date. When was the written?

3, the recipients. Who were the original recipients of the book? The most important step in interpreting any biblical text is to first work very hard to discover what the original author was trying to communicate to the original audience.

4, the specific reason for writing. What are the main reasons the author wrote the book?

5, aspects of the cultural setting that relate to the purpose of the writing. What was the cultural context in the time the book was written and received?

6, references to historical people and events. Who are the people and what was the significance of certain events mentioned by the author?

7, type of literature and the nature of the book you are reading. Is it Poetry? Is it a parable? Is it an Epistle? Is it a Law? Is it an allegory? Or is it a narrative? Is it a Proverb? Or is it a History book? The type of literature used can help in understanding the message being conveyed.

8, the context. The context of a verse exists at various levels - textual, literary and historical. The first is its immediate textual context. A word is found in a sentence, a sentence in a paragraph and a paragraph in a chapter.

When you do a personal Bible study, you can get more insight and understand the true meanings of certain Bible passages. As a Christian, you may come across people who will disagree with certain interpretations of some portions of the Bible. When this happens, you need to handle disagreements of interpretation with the love Christ. Sometimes you could be wrong and need to re-read the Bible on that particular area and sometimes you could be right. When you find yourself in confusion, seek for the help of your pastor, and if you are in doubt, pray to God for clarity and do personal research on the matter asking God to show you the truth.

Lastly, I want to say to you, do not rush to put a full stop when you learn about something in the Bible, put a comma, because as you grow in the Lord, more light is shed by the Holy Spirit. There is need to seek for the whole counsel of God on every matter. There are no new gospels, no new revelations that can be greater than what Jesus has already revealed in Scriptures. If any man should come to you and teach you what is contrary to the teachings of the Bible, it is better to hold on to the truth you know to be true in the Bible that to make a gamble with your faith.

If you need help and have questions, you can direct them to Consuming Fire Ministries International in Zimbabwe. Feel free to send us an e-mail or call us, ask us questions and we will assist you, as God has given us the grace.

GUIDELINES FOR PREACHING (1)

The following notes were made by Apostle T. G. Mapiye.

'And He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to all creation.' (Mark 16:15)

"The Word of God can grow to be only a hunting-ground for texts; and we can preach, meaning intensely every word we utter, and yet in reality only lost for the moment like an actor in his part, or at least leaving it to the folk to live it out; for us, bless me, we have no time for that, but are already immersed, poor harried souls, in determining what we shall preach on next."- A. J. Gossip

"Give me one hundred preachers who fear nothing but sin and desire nothing but God, and I care not whether they be clergymen or laymen, they alone will shake the gates of Hell and set up the kingdom of Heaven upon Earth." ~ John Wesley

"If Jesus preached the same message minister's preach today, He would have never been crucified." ~ Leonard Ravenhill

"The gospel we preach must not be just something we hear from men or read from books or even conceived through our meditation. Unless it is delivered to us by God, it can serve no spiritual utility." ~ Watchman Nee

"It is no use walking anywhere to preach unless our walking is our preaching." ~ Francis of Assisi

"I'd rather be able to pray than to be a great preacher; Jesus Christ never taught his disciples how to preach, but only how to pray." ~ D.L. Moody

"We complain today that ministers do not know how to preach; but is it not equally true that our congregations do not know how to hear?" ~ J.I. Packer

"What is the chief end of preaching? I like to think it is this: It is to give men and women a sense of God and His presence." ~ Martyn Lloyd-Jones

Definition

In simple terms, to preach is to publicly proclaim or teach (a religious message or belief). The word preaching in Hebrew has three words, **'basar'**, which means "to bring or tell good tidings" (Psalms 40:9; Isaiah 61:1), **'qara'**, which means "to call," or "proclaim" (Nehemiah 6:7; Jonah 3:2), and **'qeri'ah'**, which means "cry," or "preaching" (Jonah 3:2); and in the Greek, **'kerux'**, which means "crier," or "herald" (1 Timothy 2:7), or **'kerusso'**, which means "to cry or proclaim as a herald" (Matthew 3:1; Romans 10:14), and **'euaggellizo'**, which means "to announce good news" (Matthew 11:5)).

Paul instructed Timothy, 'When Christ Jesus comes as king, he will be the judge of everyone, whether they are living or dead. So with God and Christ as witnesses, I command you to **preach God's message**. Do it willingly, even if it isn't the popular thing to do. **You must correct people and point out their sins.** But also cheer them up, and when you instruct them, always be patient. **The time is coming when people won't listen to good teaching**. Instead, they will look for teachers who will please them by telling them only what they are itching to hear. They will turn from the truth and eagerly listen to senseless stories.' (2 Timothy 4:1-4 CEV)

It is not always the case that when a preacher preaches God's message people will respond positively. Sometimes people don't want God's message to be preached to them, instead they want the preacher to preach sermons that will tickle them and make them feel comfortable in their wrong ways. A preacher of God's word should not bend to follow the desires of people but should always have the message that God wants to be preached to His people.

Preparation of the Vessel

'How then will they call on Him in whom they have not believed? How will they believe in Him whom they have not heard? And how will they hear without a preacher? How will they preach unless they are sent? Just as it is written, "HOW BEAUTIFUL ARE THE FEET OF THOSE WHO BRING GOOD NEWS OF GOOD THINGS!" (Romans 10:14-15)

The preacher is not the source, but is a channel that God uses to convey his messages. The life of the preacher must radiate the reality of what he preaches. Before you appear before people to preach God's message it is important to spend time alone with God and His Word. Prayerfully seek out the counsel, wisdom and instructions of the Lord in through studying the Word. Due to the law of fast forgetting it is important for the preacher to keep a notebook in which to record the thoughts and lessons that are taught by the Holy Spirit during Bible study times.

Preparation of the Message

”The preacher is not a chef; he’s a waiter. God doesn’t want you to make the meal; He just wants you to deliver it to the table without messing it up. That’s all.” ~ John MacArthur

A Good sermon shout have the following:

1) Text
2) Central truth
3) Introduction
4) Body
5) Conclusion

Tell them what you are going to say (the introduction), then say it (the body) and then tell them what you said (the conclusion). Do not bore people by preaching your whole sermon again, just highlight your main points. This will refresh their memory of something you may have said thirty minutes ago.

A preacher should be able to:

1) Choose an appropriate text for a biblical message.

2) Identify God's Good News in a text.

3) Cultivate attitudes and actions of gratitude, trust and obedience in the lives of listeners.

4) Show people how to respond to the sermon he/she has preached.

5) Set a goal for each sermon. Planning and setting goals for preaching in very vital. Not only is planning important to your overall preaching ministry, it is also imperative to the preparation and delivery of each message you preach.

6) Evaluate your sermons to see if you have met your goal, and discern whether or not your preaching ministry provides a balanced spiritual diet that can help the ones to whom you minister grow in the faith.

7) Live out the sermons he/she preaches if he/she finds himself/herself under similar circumstances.

8) Show people the central truth in the sermon. Every message you preach should have a central truth taken from the Scripture text upon which the sermon is based.

9) Give brief, simple instructions. Peter told the crowd exactly what they were supposed to do to respond to his message (Acts 2:38–39)

Your sermon should be able to achieve the following:

a) gaining the attention of the hearers.

b) explaining, illustrating, and applying the content of the Scripture passage.

c) guaranteeing spiritual response.

d) pointing the hearers to a specific course of action as a result of the message.

To come up with a relevant sermon:

Know your audience - Jesus knew the needs common to all people (Matthew 6:31–32) as well as the needs of each person (John 1:43–50) and this made him able to minister relevant sermons for people. The Holy Spirit will guide you as you seek to minister to the needs of the people. Trust and follow His leadership (1 Corinthians 2:10–12). Expect people to respond to your sermon and to achieve your goal at the end of your sermon. There is a story I once read that of a preacher who approached the distinguished preacher C. H. Spurgeon and asked, “How do we preach the same gospel and you have results and I don’t?” Spurgeon answered, “You don’t expect results every time you preach, do you?” “No,” replied the preacher. “Then that is one reason why you don’t get any!” Spurgeon exclaimed. When you preach, expect God to make something happen.

The goal of the sermon helps us to answer which one of the following questions:

a) What do I want this message to accomplish?

b) What does the text say?

c) How do I apply these truths to my hearers?

Things to avoid when preaching:

The preacher becomes the point of the sermon - This kind of preaching exalts the man and loses the gospel message.

The preacher begins to entertain the audience at the expense of the truth - While it is important to engage the audience the preacher should not get carried away and begin to entertain the audience instead of giving them God's message.

Intellectual pride - No matter how intelligent you are and how much research you have done, be careful not to make your vocabulary, knowledge and presentation skills become the focus of your congregation after ministering to them.

Preaching at random without any goals - Where there is no sermon goal, the one who ministers generally tends to drift from subject to subject without developing any course of action for the hearers to take.

Being boring to the listeners - Your sermon should not be confused or arranged disorderly such that people spend more than 30 minutes trying to understand what you are preaching about. The preacher should be engaging and not boring because the text is alive with the power of God. Jesus told countless parables (Mark 4:34). He pulled spiritual truth from everyday life. Use illustrations, examples and memorable stories to convey your message.

Looking for verses to support your personal agenda and ideas - There is a way to preach the Bible unBiblically to support a personal agenda. Such preaching should be avoided. Just because you have quoted a Bible verse does not make your sermon Biblical.

Imposing your own meaning to the text - For example, the apostle Paul's assurance that not even a hair of your heads will be lost (Acts 27:34) is not intended as a solution for baldness. The plain, literal meaning of a passage should be used unless it cannot be taken literally. Therefore, if you will take a text from Scriptures and keep close to it, you will avoid any twisting of the Scriptures.

Using only one Bible translation - avoid preaching a sermon based

on one translation of a certain text. Let your selected Bible passage

be clear and confirmed by multiple translations.

Trying to convert people by your own power and wisdom – You should never think that you can convert souls using your own power of by tricking them and lying to them.

Being too long and talkative - Some who minister have a tendency to talk unnecessarily about things that do not concern the overall objective of the sermon. When you preach, everything you say must contribute to meeting that same goal. Be mindful of the goal of the message. Your message objective is part of your ministry objective: to declare the whole purpose of God (Acts 20:27) so that the lost will find Christ and the believers will mature in the faith.

"The gospel is preached in the ears of all men; it only comes with power to some. The power that is in the gospel does not lie in the eloquence of the preacher otherwise men would be converters of souls.

Nor does it lie in the preacher's learning; otherwise it could consists of the wisdom of men. We might preach till our tongues rotted, till we should exhaust our lungs and die, but never a soul would be converted unless there were mysterious power going with it – the Holy Ghost changing the will of man. O Sirs! We might as well preach to stone walls as preach to humanity unless the Holy Ghost be with the word, to give it power to convert the soul." — Charles Haddon Spurgeon

Preaching Methods and Sermon Types:

Preaching through a Book

Preach a series of sermons through a biblical book. Instead of struggling to know what to preach about every week, preach through a book. As you preach through a book, the Spirit of God will take the Word of God and apply to the needs of the people of God. Preaching a series of sermons will also enable you preach on many topics and not just address your favourite topics. If you preach through a book, reading verse by verse and chapter by chapter, the congregation can benefit more out of your sermons. Avoid preaching the same or similar texts, subjects, and messages. Like Paul, preach the whole purpose of God (Acts 20:26–27). Study your preaching patterns carefully to see that you are not neglecting the great truths and texts of Scripture.

Bible passage based sermon

Passage-based sermons start with a verse, a group of verses, a chapter, or a book and analyse that passage in a particular way to develop a message to meet the needs of the audience.

Bible subject based sermon

Subject-based sermons, on the other hand, begin with a topic rather than a passage and focus the teachings of the Scripture from various passages on the one subject.

Preaching without notes

I have practiced this kind of preaching, where the message is spontaneous, and usually presented without notes at the time of delivery. This method is very effective when one is led by the Holy Spirit.

Pulpit Etiquette

Dress decently, modestly, smartly to look presentable and appropriately for before standing on the pulpit to preach.

Colossians 4:6, “Let your speech be alway with grace,seasoned with salt, that ye may know how ye ought to answer every man.”

Luke 4:22, “And all bare him witness, and wondered at the gracious words which proceeded out of his mouth…”

When preaching, do not look at the same person in the room. Look around.

Make eye contact with all the people and do not be shy.

Do make appropriate gestures to help illustrate the message.

Be loud as to be understood by all. Preach with emotion and charisma—do not be a boring preacher!

Do not be in a bad mood. You are not fit to be a preacher if you cannot rule your emotions! (Proverbs 25:28, 16:32).

Enjoy your sermon.

GUIDELINES FOR SELECTION OF SONGS FOR CHURCH MEETINGS

The following notes were made by Apostle T. G. Mapiye.

The Process of Selecting Songs for Church Service Praise and Worship

Being part of the Church Music Team is a wonderful privilege. It is important to allow God to use you as a team and guide you to select songs that will be used to glorify Him. You should have an understanding of the lyrics you sing and the ability to convey that understanding, love for the people you lead, ask God for wisdom in selecting the songs and verses used for worship. Selecting songs and singing them is not the only thing you should do but you also need the ability to act on the truths you sing and speak. Ask God to give you the humility to lead in a way that glorifies God instead of yourself or the congregation and the ability to guide the congregation to an improved relationship with God.

Take note of the following important guidelines:

1) Pray and seek God's guidance

There are many good songs that people can sing and many preferences. When we lead in worship we need to understand the congregation we are leading and what God is doing with the congregation. Spend time waiting on the Lord a few days before the practice session, so that God can guide you in songs selection and also prepare people's hearts for what He wants to communicate. We have a tendency to want to sing our favourite songs and this desire can divert our attention from listening to what the Holy Spirit is saying to the Church.

2) Understand Your Pastor

Know exactly what the Pastor wants and where the pastor is taking the Church. Music should not go in opposite direction with the direction of the pastor. The pastor knows what the Church needs at any

given season. There are songs which are nice and enjoyable at personal level but may not be the best songs for the Church in certain seasons. Your focus should not be on what you enjoy but on what is good for the Church. Take seriously the songs suggested by the Pastor to be sung and put them on your list.

3) Choose songs that are biblically accurate

Scripture says to “worship in spirit and in truth” (John 4:23). It is easier to worship and praise a God that you know and have a relationship with than to know songs and lead people to worship when you lack a direct relationship with the God you are leading others to worship. It is important to know the God you worship, therefore immerse yourself in the scripture that reveals Him. This doesn’t mean that every song has to quote the written word of God, but the content should square with what the Bible says about Him. Select songs which do not go against the doctrine and teachings of your Pastor. Be sure that the music you select rightly represents the truth of who God is, not the mere image of who He is thought to be.

4) Select songs which are relevant.

Don’t be afraid to teach a new song that really expresses what God is doing in the greater body of Christ –one with a fresh perspective, but don’t overwhelm them by teaching too many songs at one time. When you introduce a new song, give people printed lyrics of the song on paper so that they can sing along. When you introduce a song in another language which is not Shona or English, please translate the lyrics so that people will know that they are singing. One new song at a time is a good rule of thumb.

5) When the Pastor changes your selection of songs

Pastors have the duty to feed the flock and lead the whole Church. Pastors know the needs of the Church and prepare for the service. Sometimes they will guide you in the choice of songs to communicate a certain message to the Church.

6) Choose God-centered songs over “Me” songs or Self-centred songs

There are songs that say we are going to do this or that, and that make declarations and claims God’s promises but we are primarily there to worship God in the person of Jesus Christ. Let’s celebrate who He is, what He has done

and what He is still doing through His Holy Spirit in the name of Jesus Christ. We should sing songs that call attention to His glory (not ours). There are times when we need to make declarations and encourage ourselves in the Lord through music but most of the time we must sing praise and worship songs.

7) Support the Theme and Season

What has God been speaking to you and to the church? Is it a time of joy and celebration or mourning or somewhere in between? It's always a good idea to ask your Pastor about the theme or to observe the sermons being preached. Pastors are always in tune with what the church is going through. Does the church need: hope, joy, healing, repentance, reconciliation, or understanding? Support the theme of the Church, but don't be bound by it to forget the voice of God. So your personal theme and your favourite songs should not overshadow the theme of the Church and the voice of the Holy Spirit.

8) Do not complicate your list of songs for the service

The message of the songs must be clear and appropriate without creating monotony. If your theme is about the Power of God or the Holy Spirit, then make a list with at least 80% of the songs carrying different messages about the theme. Don't just mix songs haphazardly without order. Arrange your songs in order, preferably ascending order, starting low and going high until people reach the peak in praise and in worship.

9) Choose songs that encourage participation

Enjoy the Lord in front of them and they will want to get involved. Make it easy to do so by choosing songs that makes people participants and not spectators. Instead of, "I worship You,", let your songs have words like, "We worship You," to cater for the congregation. They should feel involved in the song.

10) Know the nature of Service and environment that you will sing under

The environment will have an impact on the songs you select. Will the music you are considering perform well in a small group, or is it best to be delivered to a larger audience? Can it be led by one person or will it be led by a team? If you have visitors coming, know that the first impression of your performance that they will get will last long in their minds.